

THE WORLD IS GREEN

TROPHIC CASCADES

IN CONTEXT

KEY FIGURE

Nelson Hairston (1917–2008)

BEFORE

1949 Aldo Leopold publishes *A Sand County Almanac*, drawing attention to the ecological impact of hunting wolves on mountain plant life.

AFTER

1961 Lawrence Slobodkin, an American marine ecologist, publishes *The Growth and Regulation of Animal Populations*, a key ecology textbook.

1980 Robert Paine describes the "trophic cascade effect," when predators are removed from an intertidal ecosystem.

1995 The reintroduction of gray wolves to Yellowstone National Park sets in motion a series of ecosystem changes.

Soon after the end of World War II, Aldo Leopold, an ecologist and one of the top wildlife management experts in the United States, challenged the view that wolves should be eradicated because they threatened livestock. In *A Sand County Almanac*, he wrote of the destructive effect that removing this top predator would have on the rest of the ecosystem. In particular, he said, it would lead to overgrazing of mountainsides by deer. Leopold's view